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LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

Boston artist Alison Croney Moses worked on a scale model of her installation as she prepared for the Boston Public Art Triennial.

Making staid civic spaces history

Boston Public Art Triennial will emphasize the ephemeral and experimental

“THE KNOWLEDGE KEEPERS”

The MFA's contribution to the Triennial effort is a pair of chromium sculptures by the Mohawk artist Alan Michelson. It's a tacit response to “Appeal to the Great Spirit,” which was erected in a very different age.



By Murray Whyte
GLOBE STAFF

For decades — even a century or more — public art in Boston has been easy to define: By material (granite, marble, bronze), by format (human figures, usually on horseback, usually male) and by theme (historic, historic, and historic; the older the better).

But in recent years — slowly, sometimes painfully — a new vision of Boston has begun to emerge. That was never more clear than in late 2022, when “The Embrace,” Hank Willis Thomas's confounding, colossal tangle of hands and arms, arrived on Boston Common. A memorial to Martin Luther Jr. and Coretta Scott King, it loudly proclaimed a shift that had labored to express itself in whispers.

While Boston has surely lagged its urban peers as it stood pat on an old vision of itself, it's about to make up for lost time: Next month, the Boston Public Art Triennial will arrive with two dozen new works displayed downtown and across the city, in neighborhoods from Charlestown to Mattapan. Partnered with the city's venerable art museums as well as the city itself, the

ART, Page A9

Exodus leaves IRS in chaos

Leaders quitting as Trump keeps the pressure on

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — For decades, the Internal Revenue Service has cultivated a reputation as a force of wonky, drama-free, and borderline-boring accountants who fulfill the unpopular task of collecting the cash that fuels the federal government.

These days, the agency is quickly developing a reputation for something else: chaos.

The return of President Trump, and his aggressive campaign to remake the government, has particularly roiled the sober tax collection agency whose activity in the past has drawn the ire of conservatives.

It began on the eve of Trump's inauguration in January, when then-IRS commissioner Danny Werfel resigned rather than be fired by Trump, who had already named his own pick to run the agency.

That development alone was

IRS, Page A6

Foreign students fight back in courts

By Shelley Murphy and Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

International students in Boston and across the country whose legal status was abruptly “terminated” by the government without warning or explanation are increasingly pursuing a preemptive legal strategy — they are seeking emergency court orders that temporarily bar the government from arresting or deporting them.

In separate but similar cases filed this month, federal judges granted temporary restraining orders that prevent the government from taking action against three Chinese nationals at Boston University, Northeastern University, and MIT who allege US Immigration and Customs Enforcement unlawfully stripped them of their immigration status. Other cases are pending.

The students are urging federal judges to set aside ICE's termination of their lawful status so they can continue their studies as legal proceedings unfold. Otherwise, they would essentially be looking over their

STUDENTS, Page A6

A Boston mayoral race preview — or maybe not

S.F. campaign had parallels, and differences

By Emma Platoff and Niki Griswold
GLOBE STAFF

An heir to a prominent billionaire family runs for mayor, armed with extensive non-profit experience but no government background. He promises an outsider's approach and a fresh start to residents crying out for more and cheaper housing, and to downtown businesses reeling from the pandemic's economic aftershocks. After a bruising campaign, he pulls off an unexpected victory, defeating the city's powerful incumbent

mayor, the first woman of color elected to lead the city.

No, this isn't a prediction for Boston's future or a Josh Kraft fever dream — it's the story of the 2024 mayor's race in San Francisco, where Levi's heir Daniel Lurie toppled incumbent London Breed in the most expensive contest in the city's history.

On its face, the year-old race has striking parallels to the upcoming election in Boston, where barrier-breaker Mayor Michelle Wu faces a challenge from Kraft, the non-profit leader and third son of billionaire Patriots owner Robert Kraft. The West Coast race showed how a wealthy outsider can unseat an incumbent mayor in a famously pro-

MAYOR, Page A8

‘I don’t want to be working eight or more hours a day, then have to wait on a train for it to not show up.’

CHRISTOPHER KEARNS, *commuter*

New rail line spinning its wheels

With staffing low, South Coast forced to use shuttle buses

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

After decades of fits and starts, eager locals woke up before dawn last month to celebrate the arrival of commuter rail service from Fall River and New Bedford directly to Boston's South Station, a 90-minute train ride.

But since then, issues have cropped up. Delayed and canceled trains have left some passengers stranded at stations. Over the busy holiday weekend, a spate of trips were re-

placed with shuttle bus service.

Now, some who were once excited about taking the South Coast Rail are having serious doubts about the reliability of service. The MBTA attributes the cancellations to staff shortages.

“Obviously, because this is so new to Fall River, it's very disappointing,” said Fall River Mayor Paul Coogan. “My hope is that going forward, they're able to correct these mistakes and either put out a schedule they can comply with or not run the trains and tell people those trains are not available.”

Since the launch on March 24, service disruptions on the

New Bedford/Fall River Line — a project that cost more than \$1 billion between building new stations and tracks — have been reported daily, according to a review of posts on X from MBTA Commuter Rail Alerts, an official account.

A private contractor, Keolis, runs the agency's commuter rail operations and maintenance.

Between Saturday and Sunday, a total of 18 trips — inbound and outbound — were replaced with shuttle buses due to a lack of staffing, according to a Keolis spokesperson. Amid the troubles plaguing the new line, the MBTA

TRAINS, Page A9

Peggy O'Keefe took the stand in Karen Read's retrial and became emotional as she talked about the death of her son, John. **B1.**

Members of the state's congressional delega-

tion condemned the living conditions of Louisiana detention facilities where the Trump administration is holding immigrants. **B1.**

US births increased by just 1 percent in 2024,

still near the record low rates that have alarmed demographers. **A2.**

Vice President JD Vance called on Ukraine to accept a US peace proposal that closely aligns with Russian goals. **A3.**

CELTICS TAKE CARE OF BUSINESS

Playing without injured star Jayson Tatum on Wednesday night, Boston was carried by Jaylen Brown, who scored 36 points in the 109-100 win over Orlando at TD Garden. The Celtics, up 2-0 in the first round of the postseason, will play Game 3 Friday night in Orlando. **C1.**



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00

Rayson d'être

Thursday: Sunny, pleasant. High 60-65.

Friday: More of the same. High 65-70.

High tide: 8:43 a.m., 9:15 p.m.

Sunrise: 5:49 Sunset: 7:36

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C11.

